NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠6

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 2♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣2

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠7

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥5

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣10

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦K

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A 8 2
♥ A 10 8 2
♦ A 3
♣ K Q 10 4

♠ Q 10 3
♥ Q 9 5
♦ J 9 8 6
♣ A 7 3



♠ K J 9 6 4
♥ J 7 3
♦ 10 5 2
♣ 5 2

♠ 7 5
♥ K 6 4
♦ K Q 7 4
♣ J 9 8 6

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠6

Partner's 2NT bid invites you to bid game if you have a maximum hand. Your 17 points is certainly a maximum so you bid 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♠6. Will you take your ♠A immediately? or at trick 2? or trick 3?

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 6

You need 3 more tricks, and they must come from ♣s. So you must drive out the ♣A. The problem is that when the defenders win the ♣A they may also take 4 ♠ tricks.

While you cannot guarantee the contract you can at least give yourself a better chance by holding up your ♠A on the first trick, and also on West's ♠ continuation. You win the third ♠ with your ♠A.

Now you drive out the ♣A. There are four possibilities:East may win the ♣A and cash two more ♠s, down 1. East may win the ♣A and cash just one ♠s, you make it. West may win the ♣A and have a fourth ♠ to lead, you make it. West may win the ♣A and be out of ♠s, you make it.

If you win the first or second ♠ trick you will fail. When you attack ♣s, West will win the ♣A and play a ♠.

Holding up twice can never hurt, and in this case it is the only way to make the contract.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K 7 ♥ J 10 9 8 ♦ J 9 7 2 ♣ Q 9 5	
♠ J 9 8 6 4 2 ♥ 4 ♦ K 6 5 3 ♣ 8 3	N W E S	♠ 10 5 ♥ A Q 6 2 ♦ A Q 4 ♣ A J 7 4
	♠ A Q 3 ♥ K 7 5 3 ♦ 10 8 ♣ K 10 6 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♥	Pass	2♠	
All Pass			

2♠ by East
Lead: ♣2

In the pre-transfer days you would have bid 2♠ with this hand and partner would have passed. Now you make partner bid the ♠s first by saying 2♥. Partner dutifully replies 2♠.

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You say pass.

The contract would be 2♠ played by West.

East plays 2♠. South leads the ♣2. North plays the ♣Q which you take with your ♣A.

Loser List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5Count losers in the long-trump hand, (dummy this time).

You can make the contract if you just force out their big trumps. But there is another tempting possibility. You could enter dummy with the ♦K and play the ♥4, finessing North for the ♥K. If the finesse is successful you could then discard dummy's ♣ loser on the ♥A.

Should you or shouldn't you?

The reward for this play would be an overtrick. The price of failure would be going down in a cold contract. So obviously, at rubber bridge, you would be foolish to take such a risk. Playing Duplicate though, you **might** consider it. But let's say you decide to play safe.

Win the ♣A and play a trump. As soon as you get in play another trump. The defenders will no doubt take their ♣ winner when they get in. North will no doubt win one of those high trump tricks, and he MAY lead a ♥ when he gets in. There you will be, trying to decide again whether to finesse . . .

As you see, the ♥K is in the wrong place this time, but might be right the next time.

Usually you should not risk your contract for the sake of an overtrick.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ J 4 ♥ A 9 8 5 ♦ J 10 7 3 ♣ K 8 2	
♠ Q 10 8 7 3 ♥ 6 4 2 ♦ 9 5 ♣ Q 9 5	N W E S	♠ A 9 2 ♥ J 10 7 3 ♦ A 6 4 ♣ J 6 3
	♠ K 6 5 ♥ K Q ♦ K Q 8 2 ♣ A 10 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♦
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠7

Partner's 2♣ is Stayman convention. With no 4-card Major suit your response is 2♦. Partner now bids 2NT.

Partner's 2♣ is Stayman convention. With no 4-card Major suit your response is 2♦. Partner now bids 2NT.

The 2NT bid is invitational, asking you to bid game with a maximum, pass with a minimum. You have 17 points so you bid 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠7. You put on dummy's ♠J, but East wins the ♠A then continues with the ♠9. Do you play your ♠K now?

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 6

You need 3 more tricks, and they must come from ♦s. So you must drive out the ♦A. The problem is that when the defenders win the ♦A they may also take 4 ♠ tricks.

This is another case where you should hold up. Allow EW to win the second trick and take your ♠K only at trick #3.

Now you drive out the ♦A. If West has it and also started with 5 ♠s you will go down. But if East has the ♦A you will make the contract no matter how ♠s split.

If you win the second ♠ East will still have a ♠ when he wins the ♦A.

But if you hold up your ♠K East will have no ♠ to put his partner in with.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ J 7 4 3 ♥ K J 9 5 ♦ Q 9 5 ♣ 8 5	
♠ K 8 5 ♥ A 2 ♦ A 7 3 ♣ A K Q 7 2	N W E S	♠ Q 9 ♥ 8 4 3 ♦ K J 10 8 2 ♣ J 10 4
	♠ A 10 6 2 ♥ Q 10 7 6 ♦ 6 4 ♣ 9 6 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♥5

Even if you wanted to show your ♦ suit how would you do it? If you bid 3♦ it would be a transfer and if you bid 4♦ you would have bypassed 3NT, your probable best contract.

But you didn't want to bid them anyway, you just wanted to bid 3NT, right?

The contract would be 3NT played by East.

North leads ♥5, South plays the ♥Q.

The first thing you need to decide is whether to hold up on the ♥.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 5 :: Total = 8

First decide the holdup question. North led the ♥5 and you can see the ♥4, ♥3 and ♥2. Assuming North led fourth down he must have only a 4-card suit since there are no cards he could have lower than the ♥5. With ♥s splitting 4-4 a holdup would do no good, and isn't necessary anyway.

So take the ♥A. Then what?

You COULD try the ♦ finesse. Even if it loses it would establish several ♦ winners. However, if the defenders win just 1 ♦ trick they will quickly grab their 3 ♥ tricks and their ♠A and put you down 1.

This is why it is important to You need just one additional winner and all you have to do to get it is play a ♠ honor.

When you can see all four hands, including the location of the ♦Q, it kind of makes you wished you had finessed and gotten all those overtricks.

Good Bridge players like to take tricks, but they are not greedy.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A Q 10 2 ♥ K 7 ♦ K Q 7 3 ♣ K 7 5	
♠ 9 6 ♥ Q 10 8 3 ♦ J 9 6 2 ♣ Q J 3	N W E S	♠ 7 4 ♥ 9 6 5 ♦ A 10 8 4 ♣ 10 9 8 2
	♠ K J 8 5 3 ♥ A J 4 2 ♦ 5 ♣ A 6 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	3♠	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♦[2]	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

6♠ by North
Lead: ♣10

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer; he expects you to bid 2♠. However, with such great ♠ support and an outside doubleton your hand now revalues to 18 points - more than an opening 1NT. You indicate this with a jump to 3♠. This is called a "Super-Accept". Partner now bids 4NT. What do you answer?

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer; he expects you to bid 2♠. However, with such great ♠ support and an outside doubleton your hand now revalues to 18 points - more than an opening 1NT. You indicate this with a jump to 3♠. This is called a "Super-Accept". Partner now bids 4NT. What do you answer?

Blackwood, and with one Ace you answer 5♦. Partner bids 6♠ and everybody passes.

Obviously you aren't going to hold up on the ♣ lead. It won't matter where you take it, but assume you win in your hand.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 2

Since the ♦ loser is a sure thing you will need to find somewhere to discard a ♣. There are three possibilities:Finesse East for the ♥Q. (50% chance)Try to drop the ♥Q by ruffing the third round. (also about 50%)Establish a ♦ honor. (100% certain)

First pull trumps, ending in dummy. It takes two rounds. Next play the ♦5 toward your ♦Q. East wins this and plays another ♣. Win the ♣, come to your hand with the ♥K, then play your good ♦Q, discarding dummy's losing ♣.

You will need to ruff two ♥s in your hand, but the rest of the tricks are yours.

This was pretty easy because the trumps split 2-2.

If they had been 3-1 you would have had to leave the last trump undrawn until after you had ruffed two ♥s in your hand.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ 10 9 7 2 ♥ A 8 ♦ 10 8 3 ♣ 10 9 6 4	
♠ A J 6 ♥ Q J 9 7 5 2 ♦ 6 4 2 ♣ 8	N W E S	♠ K 4 ♥ K 10 4 3 ♦ A 7 5 ♣ K Q J 2
	♠ Q 8 5 3 ♥ 6 ♦ K Q J 9 ♣ A 7 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♦	Pass	2♥	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			

4♥ by East
Lead: ♦K

With 10 points and a 6-card ♥ suit you want to transfer. You say 2♦ and partner bids 2♥.

With 10 points and a 6-card ♥ suit you want to transfer. You say 2♦ and partner bids 2♥.

You know you want to play in ♥s since partner will have at least 2 of them. Your problem is whether to merely invite with 3♥ or go ahead and bid the game. Since partner has either 15, 16 or 17 points you should probably just bid 4♥. The worst thing that could happen is that partner would be playing game with only 25 points.

The contract would be 4♥ played by West.

East plays 4♥. South leads the ♦K. Do you hold up or not?

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4

There is no reason to hold up. Besides, you have bigger problems to deal with.

After you take the ♦A at trick one you have four fast losers staring you in the face the instant you lose the lead. So do you pull trumps now?

No, you dare not touch trumps yet - remember those 4 fast losers.

You cannot avoid the ♥A and ♣A, so you must get rid of one of the ♦ losers before you play trumps.

Win the ♦A, play the ♠K, then finesse the ♠J. If the finesse works discard a ♦ on the ♠A, then pull trumps. If the finesse fails you will go down 2 instead of 1.

You made it - on a 50% chance.

When the cards MUST lie in a particular way for the contract to be makeable, just assume that's the way they lie and go for it.